SEARCH DOG

BY REBEKAH WHITE

I'm curled into a ball under a mānuka tree, trying to make myself as small as I can. I'm playing hide-and-seek with Roxy, and she keeps winning.

Twigs jab at my head when I look around. I can't see much. I can hear running water and birds singing. Then I hear splashing, and Roxy bursts through the scrub. She sits beside me and barks loudly.

Roxy's trainer, Jana, appears and throws a toy into the air. Roxy rushes out of the undergrowth and jumps up and grabs it. "Yes!" says Jana. "Yes!"

Roxy is learning to be a search dog. But first, she must pass a difficult test, and I've been helping with their training. Jana and Roxy practise together most days. It takes two or three years to train a search dog.



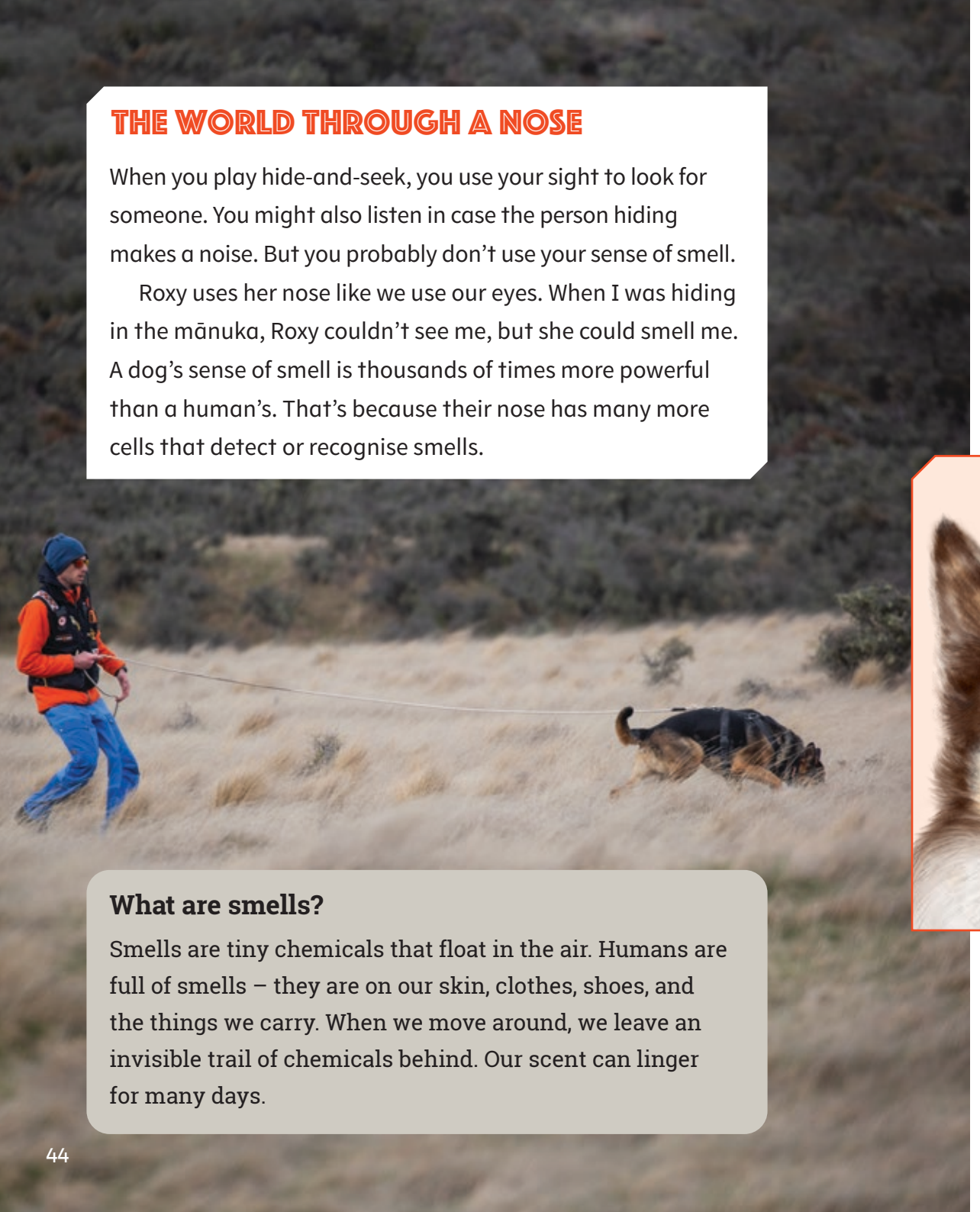
Finding lost people

Land Search and Rescue helps to find lost, missing, or injured people all around Aotearoa. The searchers are volunteers who don't get paid for their work. They rescue people in all kinds of places: cities and towns, forests and national parks, and along the coast. Search dogs are often used to look for children, who can be harder to find than adults because they're small and good at hiding.

THE WORLD THROUGH A NOSE

When you play hide-and-seek, you use your sight to look for someone. You might also listen in case the person hiding makes a noise. But you probably don't use your sense of smell.

Roxy uses her nose like we use our eyes. When I was hiding in the mānuka, Roxy couldn't see me, but she could smell me. A dog's sense of smell is thousands of times more powerful than a human's. That's because their nose has many more cells that detect or recognise smells.



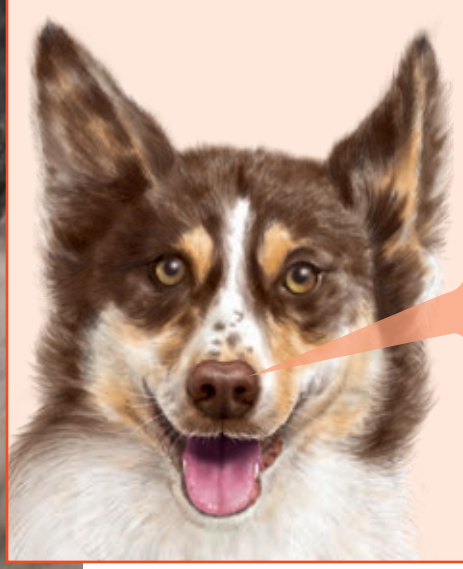
What are smells?

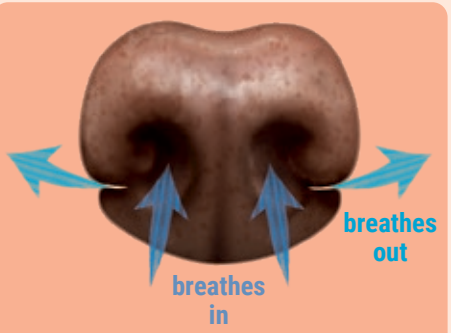
Smells are tiny chemicals that float in the air. Humans are full of smells – they are on our skin, clothes, shoes, and the things we carry. When we move around, we leave an invisible trail of chemicals behind. Our scent can linger for many days.

Humans' noses work differently from dogs' noses. We can only smell when we breathe in. When we breathe out, we let go of all the tiny chemicals in our noses that help us to smell something.

A dog can smell when it breathes in *and* out. When it lets a breath out, some of the chemicals stay in its nose. This allows it to follow someone after smelling just five of their footsteps. It can also detect a person's fingerprint a week after they have touched something.

A dog's nose





A dog breathes out through the side slits in its nostrils. At the same time, it breathes in smells through the front holes.

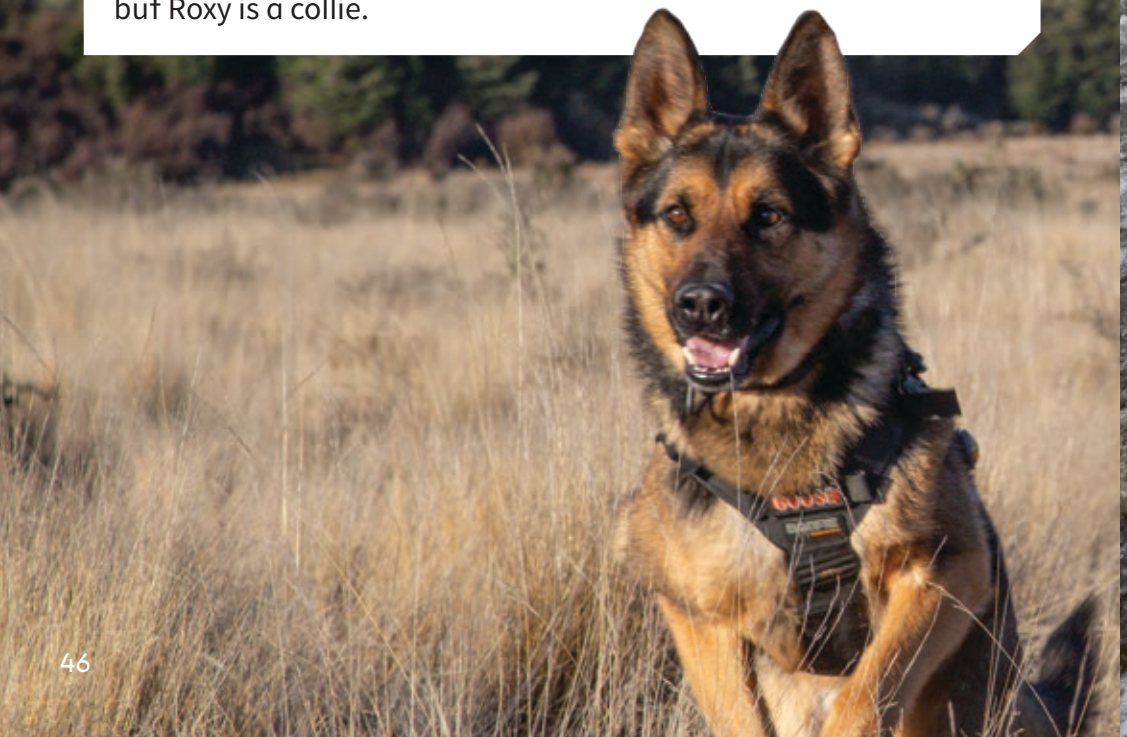
Dogs are trained to find plants, animals, insects, and polluted water. They can even detect diseases in the human body. If something has a smell, a trainer can teach a dog to find it.

ON THE JOB



Only a few dogs become search dogs. A dog with a job to do isn't the same as a pet. Search dogs need to have lots of energy and be obedient. They need to like being around people. For a dog like Roxy, the search is the most fun game she knows. When she wins the game, she gets a reward: her favourite toy.

Right now, there are seventeen search dogs working around the country. Search dogs can be big or small, and they are different breeds. Goose (the search dog below) is an Alsatian, but Roxy is a collie.



When someone is reported as missing or lost, a dog team is called in. Dogs are extra-good at searching when it's cold, damp, or wet because smells are stronger then. The hardest kind of search is when it's hot because smells become weaker in the heat.

What to do if you're lost

- Stay in one place so you don't walk into an area that has been searched.
- If you are with friends, stick together.
- Find a warm, dry spot out of the wind and rain so you don't get cold. Large boulders or tree roots make good shelter.
- Listen for people yelling your name – searchers call out when they're looking for someone.

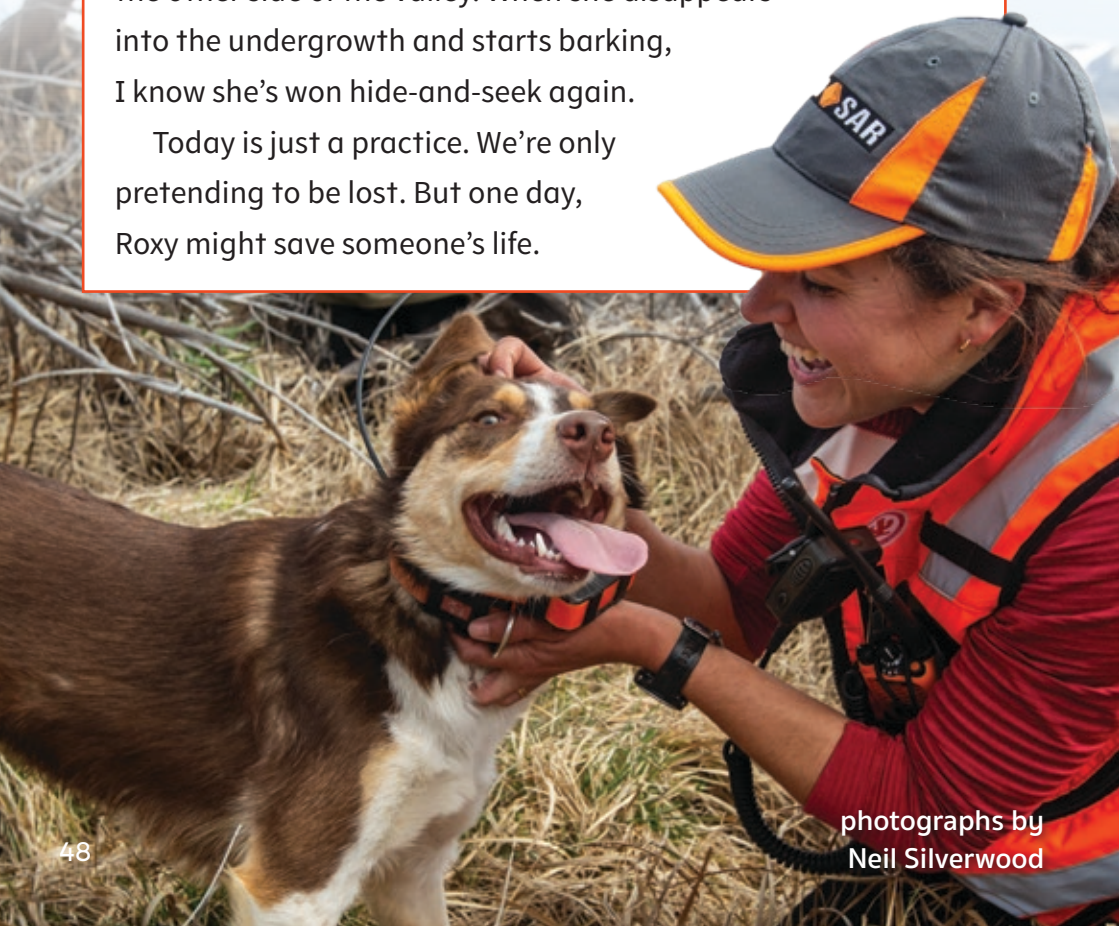
HIDE-AND-SEEK

It's time for Roxy's next game. Someone is hiding in a valley covered in long, golden grass, with dead trees all around. A creek flows through the middle.

"Searching!" Jana calls. That's the signal for Roxy to find a human scent. Together, Jana and Roxy run towards the creek. Flowing water creates a breeze, which can carry smell chemicals.

When Roxy is near the water, she stops and lifts her nose. She has smelt something. She crosses the creek, then runs up the other side of the valley. When she disappears into the undergrowth and starts barking, I know she's won hide-and-seek again.

Today is just a practice. We're only pretending to be lost. But one day, Roxy might save someone's life.



photographs by Neil Silverwood

Search Dog

by Rebekah White
photographs by Neil Silverwood


SEARCH DOG

BY REBEKAH WHITE

I'm curled into a ball under a mānuka tree, trying to make myself as small as I can. I'm playing hide-and-seek with Roxy, and she keeps winning.

Twigs jab at my head when I look around. I can't see much. I can hear running water and birds singing. Then I hear splashing, and Roxy bursts through the scrub. She sits beside me and barks loudly.

Roxy's trainer, Jana, appears and throws a toy into the air. Roxy rushes out of the undergrowth and jumps up and grabs it. "Yes!" says Jana. "Yes!"

Roxy is learning to be a search dog. But first, she must pass a difficult test, and I've been helping with their training. Jana and Roxy practise together most days. It takes two or three years to train a search dog.

Finding lost people

Land Search and Rescue helps to find lost, missing, or injured people all around Aotearoa. The searchers are volunteers who don't get paid for their work. They rescue people in all kinds of places: cities and towns, forests and national parks, and along the coast. Search dogs are often used to look for children, who can be harder to find than adults because they're small and good at hiding.



The text is copyright © Crown 2024.

The diagram on page 45 by Elspeth Alix Batt is copyright © Crown.

The photographs on pages 42–43, 44–45, and 46–48 are copyright © Neil Silverwood and used with permission.

For copyright information about how you can use this material, go to:
tahurangi.education.govt.nz/copyright

Published 2024 by the Ministry of Education,
PO Box 1666, Wellington 6140, New Zealand.
education.govt.nz

All rights reserved.
Enquiries should be made to the publisher.

ISBN 978 1 77697 598 3 (online)
ISSN 2624 3636 (online)

Publishing Services: Lift Education E Tū
Editor: Sarah Wilson
Designer: Liz Tui Morris
Literacy Consultant: Melanie Winthrop
Consulting Editors: Shana Muaiava and Chez O'Donnell

SCHOOL JOURNAL LEVEL 2 NOVEMBER 2024

Curriculum learning areas	English Science: Living World Health and PE
Reading year level	Year 4
Keywords	dogs, lost, missing people, noses, search and rescue, senses, smell, volunteers

Te Tāhuhu o te Mātauranga
Ministry of Education

Te Poutāhū
Curriculum Centre

Te Kāwanatanga o Aotearoa
New Zealand Government